

Depending on your insurance, a trip to the ER could cost you anywhere from \$100 to \$500. Sometimes, these fees are waived if you're actually admitted to the hospital, but don't count on that being a sure thing. A lot of problems can be solved right on the ER floor, which means you're still responsible for that hefty fee.

The next time you have a medical emergency that isn't too serious, try going to a walk-in clinic or urgent care first. Most clinics have the capability to do x-rays and prescribe the medication you need, and will refer you to the hospital if they think it's truly necessary.

We did this before Joseph's appendectomy, or at least before we knew that's what the problem was. We weren't sure why he was having so much pain, but rather than risk a costly ER visit after our primary's hours, we went to urgent care. They were able to diagnose the problem, and promptly sent us to the hospital without the need to wonder what was going on or wait for results. We also only owed the clinic a small copay, and avoided the ER fee since Joseph was admitted for surgery.

2. CALL AROUND FOR PRICES

Every hospital has a different billing price for each procedure, and these can vary greatly whether the hospital is located in the same city, or a few hours away. If you're considering any sort of surgery or hospital service, place a few calls to see where you can get the best deal. Obviously, the credibility and reputation of the doctor is number one, but it doesn't hurt to shop around just in case you need to negotiate later.

Remember, there are always additional costs like anesthesiologists, x-ray techs, and various medications in addition to the surgeon, so don't forget to gather prices for each of those itemized charges as well.

HealthCareBlueBook.com will quickly do this for you.

Make sure absolutely everything is considered in-network for your insurance. If you go out of network, you could encounter thousands more than you were originally expecting. Some insurance plans pay less for out-of-network hospitals and doctors, or they may not pay anything at all. Call